

ASHENFALL — Story Bible: The World of Vantyra

Companion document to DESIGN.md (v0.7) · Solo · Three acts · Four endings Prepared 2026-09-26

1. Themes

- **You are the disaster you're cleaning up.** The pilgrim is not a hero. The pilgrim is the cause.
 - **History is written by whoever survived it.** Nine nations, nine contradictory accounts of the same night.
 - **The world is wounded, and the wounds are places.** Every ruined structure is a scar with a name.
 - **Duty is a kind of death.** The last champion has held the world together for twelve centuries by refusing to stop, and he is *tired*.
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2. Timeline

Era	Event
~2,400 years ago	The Vantyrlic Empire is founded. Nine champions are bound to Ember Seals to hold back the Ashenfall — a blight that unmakes the world, spawns mobs that don't burn in daylight, and dims the sky.

~1,800 years ago	The Empire's golden age. The imperial road network, the waystones, the nine provincial capitals. The Aether is contacted; Aetherite is brought back and used to build the Ember Forges .
~1,200 years ago	The Byzantine Choir , the Empire's scholar-priests, master the nine schools of magic and learn to <i>forge</i> new Embers. The Emperor forbids it. They forge one anyway, in secret.
The Night of Nine Sounds	The Tenth Ember is completed and it is flawed. It shatters the Nine. The Empire falls in a single night. The capital becomes the Cathedral of Ash . The Ashenfall rolls outward and never stops — it only thins with distance. Nine survivors found nine nations.
~1,200–800 years ago	The nations consolidate. Each claims a Seal Shard . Each begins telling a different story about the fall.
~800–100 years ago	Slow decline. The Seals weaken. Mobs stop fearing daylight. The sun dims. The Guild of Merchants recovers the Tenth Shard and hides it, waiting for the price to be right.
Now	A pilgrim drowns on a cold shore with a reforged Tenth Ember in their chest and no memory. The story begins.

3. The Ember Seals

Nine champions, nine Embers, one job: hold back the Ashenfall. An Ember is not a light — it is a *promise given physical form*. A Seal-bearer does not age, does not sleep, and does not stop.

When the Tenth Ember shattered them, the nine Seal-bearers did not die. They were **preserved in the moment of their duty**: the first as a lich in a cold tower, others scattered across the world as bosses, champions, and things that were once people.

The player's Ember is the Tenth — reforged, dormant, and the only thing keeping them alive. Every boss defeated feeds it. This is why the pilgrim can survive what should kill them, and why the Ember Flask (its remnant) heals at all.

3A. Magic — the two forbidden arts

Magic in Vantyra is not a skill tree. It is **a crime with a curriculum**.

The Empire knew nine schools — Fire, Ice, Lightning, Holy, Ender, Blood, Evocation, Nature, and **Eldritch** — and the Choir mastered eight of them. The ninth they could only read about. Eldritch magic requires an **Eldritch Manuscript**, consumed on reading, after which the reader can inscribe and cast it. There were never many. There are fewer now.

What the Choir actually did:

- They built the **Ember Forges** on **Aetherite** taken from the Aether — which is why the Valkyries want their property back, and why they are within their rights.
- They learned to **forge Embers**: to make a promise given physical form, instead of receiving one.
- They learned to **inscribe spells into weapons**, binding a school's power to steel. The Empire's champions carried imbued blades. That art survived; the Arcane Anvil still does it.

When the Tenth Ember shattered the Nine, magic did not die — it **scattered**. Spellcasters went to ground. The schools' knowledge became loot in magical structures. The Choir kept the most of it, and has been quietly teaching it ever since — which is why they are the only nation that can offer you a spell tier, and the only one entirely honest about what they did.

The **Witchbane Crusaders** were founded in the aftermath by people who drew the obvious conclusion: *the Forges were an abomination, and everyone who has touched an Ember since is complicit*. They are not wrong. They are merely early.

The **Necromantic** arts — debuffs, rot, curses, the raising of the dead — were never part of the Empire's nine. They are older, and they were what the Seal-bearers imprisoned in the first place. The Graveyard's Lich is the proof that the imprisonment held, and the reason the Witchbane's fear is not entirely paranoid.

4. The player

No name, no past, no class until you choose one. Found drowned on a cold shore in the Norman Remnant with a cold Ember in the chest.

What the player slowly learns:

- The Ember is the **Tenth**, and it is *theirs* — they are the one who reformed it, or the one it was forged from.
 - Their flask is the Tenth's remnant, which is why it heals and why it only refills at rest points: **an Ember can only be rekindled where someone once rested.**
 - They are not the chosen one. They are the *cause*, walking around trying to fix what they broke.
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5. The Nine Nations

Each nation is anchored by real mod content (a Millénaire culture where one exists; a KubeJS faction plus a Structory / Towns and Towers structure where it does not), each keeps a **Seal Shard**, and each tells a **different story** about the fall.

1. The Norman Remnant — *Millénaire: Normans*

Territory: the Heartlands. **Attitude:** neutral, trade-hungry. **Their account:** "The Choir grew proud and broke what they were trusted to keep. We were the Emperor's own province; we buried our dead and

rebuilt. Blame the priests." **Champion:** The Lord of the Remnant — a practical soldier who respects strength and keeps the roads open. **What they offer:** the waystone network, repair, the quest hub, Norman destriers. **Standing hooks:** defend their villages from raids (+), loot their vaults (–).

2. The Seljuk Expanse — *Millénaire: Seljuk Turks*

Territory: deserts and badlands. **Attitude:** wary; hostile if you loot their ruins. **Their account:** "The Empire fell because it stopped moving. We were the horsemen who carried its messages; we watched it rot from the saddle. Blame the throne." **Champion:** The Desert Warlord. **What they offer:** horse gear, ranged weapons, Seljuk desert steeds. **Standing hooks:** tribute (+), grave-robbing (–).

3. The Byzantine Choir — *Millénaire: Byzantines*

Territory: the old imperial roads. **Attitude:** coldly curious — **they know what you are.** **Their account:** *They don't deny it.* "We forged the Tenth because the Nine were failing and the Emperor would not act. We were right about the failing and wrong about the forging. Blame us. Blame us and then tell us what you intend to do about it." **Champion:** The Archivist — the closest thing the pack has to a mentor, and the one who tells you the truth first. **What they offer:** lore, seal knowledge, **the spell tier** — the only nation that will teach you magic, and the only one that will tell you what it cost them. **Standing hooks:** the only nation that can be championed for the Empire ending.

4. The Mayan Deep — *Millénaire: Mayans*

Territory: jungles and mesas. **Attitude:** ritualistic; demands tribute. **Their account:** "The Sun was betrayed. The Tenth Ember was a second sun that failed to rise, and the sky has been dimming ever since in mourning. Blame the sky." **Champion:** The Sun-Eater — a cult leader who believes devouring Embers will restore the sun. **What they offer:** blood/alchemy gear, potions. **Standing hooks:** tribute and ritual participation (+).

5. The Yamato Shogunate — *Millénaire: Japanese*

Territory: bamboo highlands. **Attitude:** respects strength only. **Their account:** "The Empire fell because its champions hesitated. A Seal is a vow; a vow kept is a death chosen. Blame the hesitant." **Champion:** The Daimyo. **What they offers:** katana/twinblade tier, discipline gear. **Standing hooks:** proving yourself in single combat (+).

6. The Inuit North — *Millénaire: Inuit*

Territory: frozen wastes. **Attitude:** pragmatic survivors. **Their account:** "We were the farthest province. We felt the Seals break as a cold that never lifted. We don't blame anyone; we blame the cold, and we survive it." **Champion:** The Frost Warden — the first Seal-bearer, preserved as the Night Lich, and the most sympathetic boss in the pack. **What they offer:** cold-weather gear, Cold Tower intelligence. **Standing hooks:** sharing supplies (+).

7. The Spice Kingdoms — *Millénaire: Indians*

Territory: river valleys and highlands. **Attitude:** mercantile, gossip-rich. **Their account:** "Everything is trade. The Empire traded its Seals for progress. We kept the ledgers; the ledgers say the Choir paid for the Forges in Aetherite and never asked where Aetherite comes from. Blame the merchants — and yes, we know how that sounds." **Champion:** The Maharaja. **What they offer:** alchemy, **flask upgrades**. **Standing hooks:** trade and gifts (+).

8. The Norska Clans — *KubeJS faction + coastal village set*

Territory: northern coasts, Nether-adjacent. **Attitude:** raiding; ally by strength. **Their account:** "The strong take. The Empire was strong and then it wasn't. We took what the fall left. Blame the weak — and we were not weak." **Champion:** The Jarl. **What they offer:** siege weapons,

berserker gear, Norska warhorses. **Standing hooks:** raiding alongside them (+), defending against them (-).

9. The Witchbane Crusaders — *KubeJS faction + Structory fortified march*

Territory: fortified marches. **Attitude:** hostile to magic users. They know the truth. **Their account:** "The Forges were an abomination. Embers are not meant to be made; they are meant to be kept. The Tenth was a forgery of a sacred thing, and it unmade the world exactly as a forgery should. Blame the forgers — and everyone who has touched an Ember since." **Champion:** The Grand Inquisitor — who will fight you, and will be *right*. **What they offer:** anti-magic gear and the real history. **Standing hooks:** renouncing magic (+); casting a single spell near them (-40, Hexers start here).

6. Unaffiliated powers

The Guild of Merchants (*KubeJS, anchored on Millénaire trade caravans*) — Neutral. Everything has a price. They recovered the Tenth Shard a century ago and have been waiting for the price to be right. They are not evil; they are simply the only faction that correctly assessed what the Tenth Shard is worth. Antagonist reveal in Act II.

The Hollow Court (*Twilight Forest*) — The Empire's lost province, frozen mid-collapse. Its bosses are the court that never fell: the Naga is the province's guardian-beast, the Lich its vizier, the Hydra its warden, the Ur-Ghast its executioner. They are not villains; they are a place that stopped time and is still waiting for orders.

The Aether's Valkyries & the Sun Spirit — Not of this world. The Ember Forges were built using Aetherite taken from the Aether. They want their property back, and they are entirely within their rights.

The Illiger March (*vanilla woodland mansions + pillager outposts + Repurposed Structures illager variants*) — Where the Nine Nations'

enemies hold out. Not part of the old empire; opportunists who moved into the ruins.

The Lich (*The Graveyard*) — An older thing than the Empire. It was imprisoned, not created, by the Seal-bearers, and it has been very patient. Its bargain quest line is the pack's best side-story.

7. Key characters

Character	Role	Note
The Archivist (Byzantine Choir)	Mentor	Tells you the truth first, and the hardest truth last
The Frost Warden / Night Lich (Inuit North)	First boss, first Seal-bearer	The most sympathetic fight in the pack
The Lord of the Remnant	First nation champion	Practical, decent, will die for his province
The Grand Inquisitor (Witchbane)	Antagonist-ally	Right about everything, wrong about you
The Merchant (Guild)	Antagonist	Holds the Tenth Shard; will sell it, to anyone
The Harbinger	The Emperor's herald	Still waiting for a liege after twelve centuries
Maledictus	The last Emperor's champion	Holding the Nine Seals together by will, and <i>tired</i>
The Emperor	Absent	Never appears; only his letters, his city, and his champion
The Lich	Side-antagonist	Older than the Empire; patient; fair

The Sun-Eater	Cult leader	Believes devouring Embers will restore the sun
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8. The three acts

ACT I — "The Cold Shore" (Chapters 0–3)

Survival, first contact with the nations, first bosses. The pilgrim learns the rules of the world by nearly dying to them.

Beats:

1. Wake on the shore. No memory. A cold Ember in the chest.
2. The Norman Remnant takes you in; you choose a class.
3. First dungeons, first artifacts, first Ember loss.
4. **The Cold Tower.** The Night Lich. Killing it releases Seal Shard #1 into your Ember — and every nation in the world feels it.
5. The Choir sends an Archivist. The Guild of Merchants makes an offer you can't yet evaluate.
6. **The Burning Arena.** Ignis. The Mechanical Fusion Anvil — and the realisation that the good gear can only be *forged* by someone who has beaten the thing that drops its material.

Act I twist: the Night Lich was a *person* doing a *job*, and you killed them for a weapon.

ACT II — "The Nine" (Chapters 4–6)

Travel the nine nations, earn standing, hear each nation's contradictory account of the fall. Each champion holds a Seal Shard. The Hollow Court is the lost province.

Beats:

1. The Aether, and the discovery that the Forges were built with stolen Aetherite.
2. The Hollow Court — a province frozen mid-collapse, still waiting for orders.
3. Nine champions, nine Seal Shards, nine versions of history. You cannot be champion of all nine.
4. **The Lich's Bargain** — an older prisoner, a fair deal, a warning.
5. **Twist one:** the Witchbane Crusaders are right. The Ember Forges caused the fall.
6. **Twist two:** the Guild of Merchants has been sitting on the Tenth Shard for a century, waiting for the price to be right. Expose them, buy from them, or rob them.

ACT III — "Ashenfall" (Chapters 7–8)

The End is the Empire's capital. The Gauntlet is the four champions who held the line.

Beats:

1. The Emperor's Last City. The Harbinger, still waiting for a liege.
 2. Obsidilith, the Ender Golem, the Harbinger — three checks on everything you've learned.
 3. The Gauntlet: Ancient Remnant, Leviathan, Scylla, Maledictus.
 4. **Final revelation:** Maledictus is the last Emperor's champion, still holding the Nine Seals together by sheer will — and he is tired. He has been tired for twelve centuries.
 5. The ending choice.
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9. The Empire's Annals — the 12 texts

The Annals are the ending gate: **all twelve must be found, in order, to reveal the Cathedral of Ash**. Each is hidden in a reworked vanilla structure, which means the story is told *by the dungeon layer*.

#	Title	Found in	Content	Unlocks
1	The First Seal	The Drowned Chapel	The founding of the Empire and the binding of the Nine	The search begins
2	On the Nature of Embers	The Delver's End	An Ember is a promise given physical form	Codex set 1
3	The Forge Edict	The Deep Delve	The Emperor's ban on forging Embers, and his reasons	Codex set 2
4	The Choir's Confession	The Drowned Choir	The Choir admits forging the Tenth, and why	The Choir's account
5	The Tenth	The Broken Gate	How the flawed Ember was carried between worlds	Twist foreshadow
6	The Night of Nine Sounds	The Cold Tower	The first Seal-bearer's account of the fall	Frost Warden sympathy
7	Ash and Iron	The Burning Bastion	The Witchbane version: the Forges were an abomination	Witchbane account
8	The Sun-Vault Ledger	The Mayan Sun-Vault	Tribute records to a sun that stopped rising	Mayan account
9	The Seljuk Compact	The Seljuk Sand-Vault	The horsemen's account of a rotting throne	Seljuk account

10	The Emperor's Last Letter	The Emperor's Last City	The Emperor's final words to his champion	Harbinger context
11	The Warden's Vault	The Ancient City	What the Ashenfall actually is	The deepest truth
12	The Tenth Ember, Reforged	Hidden — requires all 11	Reveals the player's own nature	Cathedral of Ash location

10. The Pilgrim's Journal — the 24 pages

Fragments of the fall written by people who were there. Several are treasure maps. All 24 are required for the hidden ending.

Pages	Act	Content arc
1–4	I	A Seal-bearer's daily duty; the road network; a warning about the Forges
5–8	I–II	The night itself, from four different witnesses; the first map fragment
9–12	II	The nine provinces as they were; each nation's founding; map fragments
13–16	II	The Choir's private journals; the Aetherite theft; the Lich's imprisonment
17–20	II–III	The Ashenfall's true nature; what the Warden's Vault contains
21–24	III	The Emperor's champion; the Tenth Ember's reforging; the player's own name, which they chose before they forgot it

11. Boss lore entries

Boss	Who they were	What killing them means
Night Lich / Frost Warden	The first Seal-bearer, preserved in duty	You took a Seal from someone still doing their job
Nether Gauntlet	A Witchbane gauntlet-holder, reforged in the Nether	The Crusaders' hatred made literal
Ignis	The Burning Arena's warden — never a person	A lock, not a character
Netherite Monstrosity	What the Forges' first failed experiment became	Progress has a body count
Slider	A bronze dungeon's guardian-beast	—
Valkyrie Queen	An Aetherite warden bound to the Forges' debt	The Aether's grievance made personal
Sun Spirit	The Aether's judgement on the theft	—
Naga	The Hollow Court's guardian-beast	A province's pet, still on duty
Lich	The Hollow Court's vizier	Waiting for orders that will never come
Hydra	The Court's warden	—
Ur-Ghast	The Court's executioner	—
Obsidilith	An End-isles construct of the old empire	—

Ender Golem	The Emperor's labourer, still building	The saddest fight in the End
The Harbinger	The Emperor's herald	Still announcing a liege who is gone
Ancient Remnant	The line that held at the capital	—
The Leviathan	What the Ashenfall did to the eastern ocean	—
Scylla	The Acropolis' storm, given a shape	—
Maledictus	The last Emperor's champion	He will thank you
The Dead King	A king who found a way to not stop	He has been dead a long time, and he has made arrangements
The Keeper	The Lost Citadel's warden — never a person, a function	It keeps what the Empire could not
The Fire Boss	The Echo of Tyros — the Forges' first successful fire, given a body	Progress has a body count

12. Music disc lore

Each Cataclysm boss drops a disc; each is a named piece of in-world music with a lore entry. Ten discs, collected across the run — a small, quiet way to prove you were there.

13. The endings

Ending 1 — The Empire Rekindled

Take the Nine Seals. Rebuild Vantyra. Become its emperor. *Requires:* high standing with the Byzantine Choir. *What it costs:* the nine nations become provinces again. The Normans who fed you will be subjects. The Archivist will serve you, and will never forgive you, and will be correct. *Tone:* order, purchased with everyone else's freedom.

Ending 2 — The Pilgrim's Road

Scatter the Seals. The nations rise or fall on their own. *Requires:* high standing with at least three non-Choir nations. *What it costs:* the Ashenfall is no longer held. The dimming accelerates. Some nations will not survive the century. *Tone:* freedom, purchased with everyone else's safety.

Ending 3 — The Tenth Ember (*hidden*)

Forge a Tenth Ember properly. Become the new Seal-bearer. The Ashenfall stops. *Requires:* all 24 journal pages, one nation at +100 standing, all 12 Hollow Challenges cleared. *What it costs:* you. Bound to the world, forever, alone, holding the line — exactly what Maledictus did, except you chose it with your eyes open. *Tone:* the only ending where you live, and the only one where you don't get to leave.

Ending 4 — The Ashen Throne (*secret — the rune route*)

The Empire buried nine **Ember Runes** — not in vaults, but *behind* things: inside a riddle, at the end of a parkour route nobody walks, in the chest of a mini-boss that only spawns if you provoke it. Each capital holds one. Each rune is meaningless alone.

Assemble all nine and they point somewhere no map shows: the **Hidden**

Cathedral. Not the ruined one — a second one, built in secret, beneath the thing the Ashenfall actually is. Inside is the material the Empire used to forge the Tenth Ember, intact.

You can take it. You don't have to become a Seal-bearer, you don't have to please anyone, and you don't have to finish the road. You take the Ashen tier's core material and you walk out with the power the Empire died for, and the world goes on dimming exactly as it was.

Requires: all nine Ember Runes. No standing, no journal pages, no challenges. *What it costs:* nothing, on the day. That's the point of it.

Tone: the explorer's ending. The one for the player who never followed the road.

14. Deliberately unresolved

Left open for the player to find, argue about, and theorise:

- **Who reforged the Tenth Ember, and why did it end up in your chest?** (Page 24 answers it. Barely.)
 - **What is the Ashenfall, actually?** (Annals 11 answers it. It is worse than "a blight".)
 - **Where did the Aetherite really come from?** (The Aether has an opinion.)
 - **Who wrote the Eldritch Manuscripts, and why were there never many?**
 - **Is the Necromantic art older than the Empire, or did the Empire invent it and then forget?**
 - **Was the Emperor a tyrant, or the only person who tried to stop the Choir?**
 - **What does the Lich want, and is its bargain actually fair?**
 - **Is the Merchant's price ever the right price?**
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15. Lore delivery map

System	What it delivers
FTB Quests chapters	The main plot, with real narrative text and branching choices
The Empire's Annals (12)	The history — and the ending gate
The Pilgrim's Journal (24)	The human experience of the fall — and the hidden-ending gate
Lore Codex (24)	Who built each structure, why, and what happened to them
Village chronicles (Millénaire)	Living history you can read in any village
Boss music discs (10)	Named in-world music with lore entries
Environmental storytelling	AW2's 2000+ structures as the Empire's provinces; Repurposed Structures' out-of-place ruins as displacement scars
Faction standing	Your choices, remembered
The Ember Runes (9)	The secret mission — each hidden behind a secret in a nation capital, pointing at the Hidden Cathedral

Chapter structure, gating and landmarks are specified in PROGRESSION.md and DESIGN.md §5.2/§5.5.